

Section 1 – Words

Summary of the rules

Which words can you use?

- Rule 1.1 Use words that are:
- Approved in the dictionary
 - Technical nouns
 - Technical verbs.

Part of speech

- Rule 1.2 Use approved words from the dictionary only as the specified part of speech.

Approved meaning

- Rule 1.3 Use approved words only with their approved meanings.

Forms of verbs and adjectives

- Rule 1.4 Use only the approved forms of verbs and adjectives.

Technical nouns

- Rule 1.5 You can use words that you can include in a technical noun category.
- Rule 1.6 Use a word that is not approved in the dictionary, only when it is a technical noun or part of a technical noun.
- Rule 1.7 Do not use words that are technical nouns as verbs.
- Rule 1.8 Use technical nouns that are approved in your company, industry, or subject field.
- Rule 1.9 When you must select a technical noun, use one which is short and easy to understand.
- Rule 1.10 Do not use regional, slang, or jargon words as technical nouns.
- Rule 1.11 Do not use different technical nouns for the same item.

Technical verbs

- Rule 1.12 You can use verbs that you can include in a technical verb category.
- Rule 1.13 Do not use technical verbs as nouns.

Spelling

- Rule 1.14 Use American English spelling unless other official directives tell you differently.

Which words can you use?

Rule 1.1 Use words that are:

- **Approved in the dictionary**
- **Technical nouns**
- **Technical verbs.**

Simplified Technical English (STE) has a controlled dictionary (part 2) that gives the words most frequently used in technical writing. You can also use words that are not in the dictionary if you can include them in the specified categories of technical nouns and technical verbs.

A technical noun is a noun term that refers to a specified concept and is applicable to a subject field. A technical verb is a verb term that also refers to a specified concept or process and is applicable to a subject field.

Examples:

The word “use” is an approved verb in the dictionary.
The word “engine” is a technical noun.
The word “ream” is a technical verb.

The dictionary also gives a selection of words that are not approved, with examples that show how to use alternative words.



In the context of ISO 1087:2019, “subject fields” refer to specific domains or areas of knowledge that have specialized vocabularies.



Technical nouns and technical verbs are usually included in your company glossary or terminology database. Always refer to these sources, and to the specified rules in this section, for the correct selection of words.

Part of speech

Rule 1.2 Use approved words from the dictionary only as the specified part of speech.

In the dictionary, each approved word has a specified part of speech. When you use an approved word, make sure that you use it only as the specified part of speech.

Examples:

“Test” is an approved noun, but not an approved verb.

STE: Test B is an alternative to test A.

Non-STE: Test the system for leaks.
STE: Do the leak test of the system.

or

STE: Do a test for leaks in the system.

“Dim” is an approved adjective, but not an approved verb.

STE: A dim light comes on.

Non-STE: Dim the lights.
STE: Set the lights to the dim position.

Some words are approved as more than one part of speech. For example, “clean” is an approved verb and an approved adjective. The position of the word in the sentence shows its function (and its meaning) because verbs and adjectives have different positions.

STE: Clean the inner surface of the container.
(“Clean” is a verb here.)

STE: Make sure that the area is clean.
(“Clean” is an adjective here.)

“Acceptable” is an adjective that is not approved. The dictionary gives three approved alternatives that have the same part of speech. You can use one of these alternatives to replace the word “acceptable” in the sentence with a word-for-word replacement.

Non-STE: A value of 2 mm is acceptable.
STE: A value of 2 mm is permitted.

“Operable” is an adjective that is not approved. The dictionary gives an approved alternative that has a different part of speech: “operate” as a verb. Thus, you must use a different sentence construction.

Non-STE: Make sure that the valve is operable.
STE: Make sure that the valve can operate.

When you replace a word, always make sure that the approved alternative you select does not change the meaning of the sentence. If the meaning changes, select a different word or use a different sentence construction.



Each word in the dictionary has its part of speech in parentheses, abbreviated as specified in the introduction to the dictionary.



If a word that you want to use is not in the dictionary:

- Find that word in an English dictionary.
- Find which is the best synonym that is approved in the STE dictionary.
- Use the approved STE word or find a different sentence construction with other approved words.

Approved meaning

Rule 1.3 Use approved words only with their approved meanings.

Each approved word in the dictionary has a specified approved meaning. Some of these words can have more restricted meanings compared with their meanings in standard English. Always use the approved words only with their approved meanings.

Examples:

The approved meaning of the verb “follow” is “come after, go after.”

STE: Do the procedures that follow:

STE: Follow the green lights to the nearest staircase.

You cannot use the verb “follow” with other meanings that are not approved.

Non-STE: Follow the safety instructions.

In this sentence, always use “obey” with the approved meaning “to do that which the procedures or instructions tell you.”

STE: Obey the safety instructions.

Forms of verbs and adjectives

Rule 1.4 Use only the approved forms of verbs and adjectives.

The dictionary gives each approved verb together with its approved forms. The dictionary also gives the approved adjectives in their base form, together with their comparative and superlative forms in parentheses where applicable.

Example - Verbs:

**REMOVE (v),
REMOVES,
REMOVED,
REMOVED**

This word tells you that you can use the approved verb “remove” as follows:

Infinitive/Imperative forms	Simple present tense	Simple past tense	Past participle form (as an adjective)
(To) Remove/Remove	Remove(s)	Removed	Removed

The past participle form of the verb is usually the same as the simple past tense. Thus, the dictionary gives it two times.

Example - Adjectives:

SLOW (adj)
(SLOWER,
SLOWEST)

This word tells you that you can use the approved adjective “slow” as follows:

Base form	Comparative form	Superlative form
Slow	Slower	Slowest

Adjectives that make their comparative and superlative forms with “more” and “most” do not have these forms in the dictionary. This is because “more” and “most” are approved words.

Technical nouns

Rule 1.5 You can use words that you can include in a technical noun category.

A technical noun is a noun term that refers to a specified concept and is applicable to a subject field.

The dictionary does not include technical nouns because there are too many, and each subject field uses different technical nouns for their texts.

You can find many of these technical nouns in your company glossary or terminology database. STE gives you a list of categories, with examples, to help you:

- Select technical nouns to put in your company glossary or terminology database.
- Use technical nouns correctly.

You can use technical nouns in procedural and descriptive writing if you can include them in one or more of these twenty-two categories.

1. Official parts information

Terms that refer to all design items. For example, technical nouns included in illustrated parts catalogs or engineering drawings.

bolt, cable, clip, conductor, contact, engine, ferry tank, filter, hatch, hazard lights, indicator, light, logo, oil seal, prelubricated seal, pipe, propeller, retractor link, screw, switch, transceiver

2. Vehicles or machines, and locations on them

Terms that refer to all types of vehicles and machines, and the locations that are part of these units.

aircraft, aircraft carrier, airframe, airplane, bicycle, cabin, car, cargo compartment, cargo hold, cockpit, deck, engine room, fuselage, helicopter, galley, lifeboat, overhead panel, ship, submarine, tank, train, truck, wing, wing root

3. Tools and support equipment, their parts, and locations on them

Terms that refer to all types of tools, support equipment, their parts, and locations that are part of these items.

access ladder, blade, brush, cap, chock, clamp, cover, display, drill, file, gauge (gage), graduated beaker, handle, jack, label, rigging pin, roller, rope, rung, shaft, stand, tag, test rig, torque wrench, trestle

4. Materials, consumables, and unwanted material

Terms that refer to materials, consumable items, and other substances that can cause contamination or malfunctions.

acid, adhesive, aluminum alloy, ammunition, compound, copper, debris, detergent, dirt, disinfectant, dust, foam, foreign object, fuel, grease, hazardous substances, hazardous waste, metal, metallic coating, oil, paint, penetrant spray, plastic, primer, sealant, sealing, soap, stainless steel, tape, waste, water, wire

5. Facilities, infrastructure, and logistic procedures

Terms that refer to the management, structure, and operations of physical facilities, infrastructure systems, and logistic procedures. For example, areas for utility systems, transportation networks, storage, distribution processes, and operational logistic workflows.

airport, apron, base, building, camp, dock, engine shop floor, flight simulator, gate, handling, hangar, packaging, packing, port, service bay, shipping, shop, store, storage, transport

6. Systems, components and circuits, their functions, configurations, and parts

Terms that refer to the structure, operation, composition, and system design.

air conditioning, amplifying circuit, armament, audio, aural warning system, collapsed position, exhaust, flight management, hardware, inhibiting signal, injection, inlet, input frequency, latch, pedal, power unit, pump, reverse mode, reverse position, standby mode, upright position, vent

7. Mathematical, scientific, engineering terms, and formulas

Terms that refer to concepts, design, calculations, or methodologies.

acceleration, allowance, astronomy, atom, average, biochemistry, biology, biome, burr, capacitance, carbon, category, cavitation, center, circle, coefficient, combination, configuration, conversion, count, critical temperature, curve, cycle, defect, degree, deceleration, density, diameter, displacement, duty cycle, elapsed time, electricity, energy, exponent, failure, ferry flight, flutter, force, fumes, genetics, geology, geophysics, graph, gravity, hardness, heat treatment, idle speed, ignition, inhibition, instrumentation, interference, issue, light, line replaceable unit, load, loss, measurement, modification, momentum, motoring, overhaul, oversized hole, oxygen, performance, phase, polarity, power, pressure, process, radius, rating, ratio, reduction, relative angular position, resistance, scan, shutdown, signal, specific gravity, stall, standard, steam, stiffness, strength, suction, temperature, tension, thread, tightness, torque, toxic property, vapor, voltage, water vapor, "C = (A - B) - 0.063 mm"

8. Navigation and geographic terms

Terms that refer to positions, directions, or locations related to mapping, routing, or spatial orientation.

air, altitude, attitude, axis, bank, clearance, climb, coordinates, critical approach, datum, delay, deviation, drag, east, France, glideslope, gradient, heading, landing, leeway, Lima, north, pitch, roll, skid, south, west

9. Numbers, units of measurement and time (and their symbols)

Terms that refer to quantitative data, measurements, or time-related information.

92, 303, ampere (A), degree (°), first (1st), half (½), hour (h), kilogram (kg), knot, liter (L or l), meter (m), mile, minute ('), month, ohm (Ω), one, one-quarter (¼), second ("), second (s), second (2nd), square inch (sq.in.), spring, third (3rd), three, year, winter, zero

10. Quoted text

Terms that refer to texts that you cannot change in technical writing. For example, texts on placards, labels, signs, markings, and display units.

abort button, EXIT sign, INOP system, OXYGEN pushbutton switch, ON position, NEXT button, FAULT legend, NO STEP marking, FASTEN SAFETY BELT sign, WEAR PROTECTIVE CLOTHING sign

11. Professional roles, individuals, groups, organizations, and geopolitical entities

Terms that refer to professional functions, names of persons, organizations, companies, teams, sovereign states, or entities related to processes, responsibilities, or decision-making.

air traffic control, British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC), captain, commander, copilot, crew, crew chief, European Aviation Safety Agency (EASA), Federal Aviation Administration (FAA), John Kirkman, manufacturer, operator, Transport Canada Civil Aviation (TCCA), United States of America (USA)

12. Parts of the body

Terms that refer to anatomical features or functions related to medical, biological, or ergonomic contexts.

blood, digestive system, ear, eyes, hair, hand, head, lung, mouth, respiratory tract, skin, stomach

13. Common personal effects, food, and beverages

Terms that refer to everyday personal items and types of food and beverage.

beans, bread, cigarette lighter, clothing, coffee, flour, footwear, high-heeled shoes, jewelry, lipstick, matches, milk, mineral water, nail scissors, perfume, pizza, shampoo, wine

14. Medical terms

Terms that refer to medical conditions, procedures, or anatomical structures.

allergy, aspirin, asthma, blood poisoning, breathing, circulation, dermatitis, diabetes, dizziness, female, hallucination, headache, heart rate, irritation, male, medication, nausea, pneumonia, pregnancy, pulse, skin irritation, virus

15. Official documents, parts of documentation, standards, and guidelines

Terms that refer to different types of official documents and their structural parts. For example, manuals, technical records, standards, specifications, and regulations requirements.

Acceptance Test, Activation/Deactivation, Allowable Damage, attention, caution, chapter, Checklist, Class, Cleaning, Compass Correction Card, danger, data module, Description and Operation, diagram, engine logbook, Federal Aviation Regulations, Fault Isolation, figure, flowchart, font, Functional Test, Ice and Rain Protection, Inspection/Check, issue, language policy, letter, maintenance planning, maintenance practice, maintenance records, Normal Braking, note, notice, packaging, page, paragraph, parentheses, post-flight report, post-mod, pre-mod, prerequisite, preservation, reference, Removal/Installation, Required Conditions, Repair Scheme, recommendation, revision, section, Service Bulletin, Standard Practices Manual, storage, Structural Repair Manual, table, test procedure, training material, Transportation, valid welding certificate, warning

16. Environmental and operational conditions

Terms that refer to external factors and operating parameters that are related to systems or processes.

atmosphere, cloud, day, daylight, ice, hail, humidity, lightning, moisture, night, rain, relative humidity, sand, snow, storm, turbulence, volcanic ash, wind

17. Colors

Terms that refer to colors that identify color-related properties, or show color attributes in different contexts.

beige, black, cyan blue, dark brown, gray, green, magenta, light green, orange, red, white, yellow



Colors are adjectives, but STE identifies them as technical nouns. Comparative and superlative forms of colors (for example, blacker, the reddest) are not permitted in STE.

18. Damage terms

Terms that refer to types of defects or degradation and give information about malfunctions.

buckle, chafing, corrosion, crack, crack propagation, deformation, dent, discoloration, distortion, erosion, fracture, fraying, galling, kink, nick, score, scratch, stain, spurious fault message

19. Computer science, information and communication technology

Terms that refer to technological concepts, systems, or components in this subject field.

add-in, add-on, AI, arrow, artificial intelligence, authentication, backup, backup file, bookmark, chatbot, content, cursor, cybersecurity, database, deep learning, dialog check box, digitalization, digitization, e-mail, embedding, field, file, firewall, hallucination, HTML, icon, interface, internet, laptop, large language model, local operation, machine learning, memory, menu, metadata, mouse, network, operating system, phone, plug-in, pre-loaded software, preset value, prompt engineering, remote operation, screen, search engine, smartphone, status bar, store, tablet, token, toolbar, touchscreen, tweet, tuning, update, voice mail, XML

20. Civil and military operations

Terms that refer to concepts and activities, service delivery, product management, and customer and life-cycle support in civil and military operations.

armed forces, assault, bomb, bullet, checkpoint, combat plan, contractor, customer, customer support, customer service, deployment, echelon, ejection seat, end item, end user, evacuation, formation, ground zero, gun, Integrated Product Support (IPS), know-how, lifecycle, machine gun, maintenance concept, mission, obsolescence, operator, Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM), patrol

21. Law and regulations

Terms that refer to legal and regulatory texts. For example, contracts, warranty texts, certificates, standards and specifications, and legal papers.

action, ambiguity, appeal, arbitration, bankruptcy, communication, competence, compliance, concession, contract, court, damages, explanation, explanatory text, impeachment, jury, law, judgement, jurisdiction, purpose, recommendation, scope, serious incident, serious offense, signature, statute, term, trade, waiver, wording

22. Animals, plants, and other life forms

Terms that refer to biological entities in technical and environmental contexts.

bacteria, bird, cassowary, cat, conifer, cow, dog, emu, fern, ferret, fungi, horse, insect, leopard, monkey, moss, mouse, pocket gopher, rose, termite, wombat